Its obvious scale and ambition aside, *Ghost-eye* is a propulsive read, with the plot accelerating in the second half. And it would have been the easiest thing to let the 'action-heavy' bits dominate, with the science and the mysticism taking a backseat. But Ghosh goes the other way and amps up the symbolism and the supernatural imagery in pace with the plot. Tipu's enquiries, Dinu's trips down memory lane, and the Lusibari flashback sequences converge in an explosive finish. Without revealing too much, we can say that the denouement revolves around 'super-adapters', prodigies who have a greatly enhanced ability to adapt to their ecosystem.

"The phrase 'ecosystem people', which I actually associate with the work of Ramachandra Guha, refers to entire communities," says Ghosh. "A prodigy on the other hand is by definition a kind of singularity, an exceptional child or person. But I do think there are people who are exceptionally finely attuned to their surroundings, and often these are the very people who become shamans. This is certainly true of the 'bauley' of the Sundarbans."

For Amitav Ghosh fans, *Ghost-eye* is an expansive, impeccably crafted five-course meal. For everybody else, especially Ghosh newbies, it acts as the alluring entrée that will inevitably lead you to explore his large and increasingly interconnected body of work. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

FICTION ▼

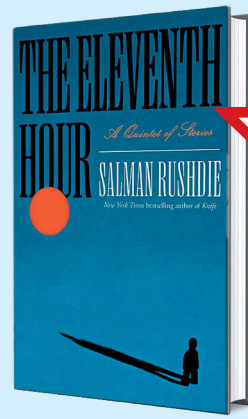
Compulsive Storyteller

Defiantly prolific, SALMAN RUSHDIE is back with *The Eleventh Hour*, a collection of short stories

How do you write about Salman Rushdie? He has transcended literature—a terrible fate for any writer—and become a symbol, a standard-bearer for free speech. Except when his speech irritates, as it recently did Hindu nationalists outraged by him expressing concern for the "attack on freedoms of journalists, of writers, of intellectuals". And yet, the magnificent thing about Rushdie is that he perseveres, he refuses to stop telling stories.

In *Knife*, he writes: "Language was my knife. If I had unexpectedly been caught in an unwanted knife fight, maybe this was the knife I could use to fight back." *Knife* (2024) was Rushdie's account of being stabbed onstage in 2022 by Hadi Matar who claimed to dislike the writer because he "attacked Islam". Rushdie lost sight in one eye and suffered severe nerve and organ damage.

But Rushdie has prevailed. He has continued to wield his knife. Three of his books have been published since he was stabbed (though the manuscript for *Victory City* was completed before the attack), the latest of which is *The Eleventh Hour*, a collection of five longish short stories.



THE ELEVENTH HOUR
A Quintet of Stories
By Salman Rushdie
PENGUIN/ HAMISH HAMILTON
₹899; 264 pages

The stories, like Woody Allen's later films, are, for fans, a reprise of techniques and themes he has used to greater effect in his best work. It is like stepping into a comforting, if tepid, bath. "Kahani," he writes of his sentimental recreation of a Bombay that might never have existed, "is here to stay, at least it is for me." And, frankly, that alone is cause for celebration.

Rushdie is in what he called in *Knife* his "second-chance life" and every word is a rebuke of those who would have him silenced. It may be true that the stories in *The Eleventh Hour* read like outtakes, left with good reason on the cutting room floor, from Rushdie's magnum opuses, but that he continues to put pen to paper is, for this reader at least, enough. The optimist's view is that this is not an inferior coda to a brilliant career, but a series of throat-clearing exercises as he builds to a second-chance crescendo.

Every word Rushdie writes should be imbued with, as he puts it in the opening story in *The Eleventh Hour*, the gleeful "scorn of life for death". ■

—Shougat Dasgupta